

REBUILD

15 THINGS THAT ACTUALLY WORK
AFTER YOU LOSE HIM — OR YOURSELF



— Zane
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You're Not Broken, You're Being Rebuilt

It's 2am and you're standing in the kitchen light because the bed got too loud. Your phone is on the counter, face up, no notifications. You opened the fridge twice and took nothing. Earlier today you stood in a supermarket aisle, in front of the pasta, and couldn't remember what you like. Twenty years of cooking for other people and you can't pick a sauce for one.

You've tried the generic stuff. Bubble baths. Wine. A book that told you to love yourself more, as if love were a tap you could turn. Your friends mean well: "Time heals." "Plenty of fish." "Stay busy." None of it touched the place that actually hurts — the chest, the gut, the 2am jolt. And here is the thing nobody told you: that failure was not your failure. Generic advice is built for generic pain. What happened to you was specific. Him leaving, or the affair, or the slow decade of shrinking until you couldn't find yourself in your own marriage — that deserves specific tools.

That's what this is. Fifteen small moves. Every one takes ten minutes or less. Every one comes with the science and the receipts — real words from real women who used them in parked cars and bathroom sinks and the worst nights of their lives.

Quick honesty about me: I'm not a guru. I'm not a therapist. I'm not a man who's going to explain your own life to you. I'm a guy who listened — really listened — to hundreds of women describe the exact moment they knew they had to start over. My mum was the first. You'll meet her in a few pages. The women in this book are the heroes; I just brought the toolbox.

One rule before we start. This book is sequenced body-first. When the wave hits, your thinking brain is flooded and offline — no affirmation survives that. So we calm the body before we ask the mind to do anything.

You're not broken. You're being rebuilt. Let's start with the body.

— ZANE

CALM THE BODY FIRST

Grief doesn't live in your thoughts. It lives in your chest, your throat, the pit of your stomach — and you can't argue with a racing heart. These first four hacks are physical on purpose. Get the body out of alarm, and the mind will follow.

— ZANE

The Emergency Brake

THE MOMENT IT SAVES: You jolt awake at 2am. Heart pounding so hard you can feel it in your teeth. The nightmare was about him — or worse, it wasn't a nightmare, just the memory arriving on schedule. Your brain is offering you nothing except more panic. You cannot think. This is exactly when this hack exists.

THE HACK:

1. Fill the bathroom sink with cold water. The colder the better — toss in ice cubes if you have them.
2. Bend over the sink. Take a breath and hold it.
3. Put your face in — forehead to chin, making sure the cold water covers your eyes and the tops of your cheekbones. Stay for 10 to 30 seconds.
4. Come up. Breathe. Repeat once or twice if you need to.
5. No-sink version for a parked car or a quiet office: press something cold and wet — a water bottle, a cold cloth, an ice pack — against your closed eyes and cheekbones while you hold your breath.

Total time: about one minute.

WHY IT WORKS: Cold water on the eyes and cheeks, plus a held breath, triggers the dive reflex — an ancient built-in switch that tells your heart to slow down, fast. This isn't a metaphor. In a 2022 review of the research, scientists found the response reliably kicks the body's calming system into gear within seconds. Therapists teach this exact move as an emergency skill for overwhelming emotion, because it works when thinking is impossible. One woman on a recovery forum put it plainly: "Best thing if you're in a panic attack already is to put ice cold water on your face."

HONEST SCIENCE FLAG: Because this move slows the heart on purpose, skip it if you have a heart condition or take heart medication like beta-blockers — your doctor can suggest a safer version. For everyone else, it's startling but safe.

You can't out-think a 2am heart attack of grief. But you can pull the brake.

— ZANE

The 20-Second Hold

THE MOMENT IT SAVES: The wave doesn't wait for a convenient time. It hits mid-meeting, when someone asks how you're doing and your throat closes. It hits on the school run, at the red light. It hits in the supermarket aisle next to the cereal he liked. You need a tool nobody can see.

THE HACK:

1. Wherever you are, place one hand flat over your heart. Place the other on your belly.
2. Breathe slowly and just notice the warmth and weight of your own hands. No need to breathe "right" — just slow.
3. Hold it for at least 20 seconds. Thirty is better.
4. Name what's there, silently: "This is grief." "This is loneliness." "This hurts, and that's okay."
5. Then carry on with the meeting, the checkout line, the school run.

Total time: 20 to 30 seconds.

WHY IT WORKS: Your own warm hand is not a placebo. In a 2021 clinical trial, researchers put people through a stress test, then had them use this exact self-soothing touch — hand on the body, twenty seconds. Their stress-hormone levels dropped measurably and recovered to normal faster than the control group. The detail I love most: the participants rated their own touch *more pleasant than receiving a hug*. The hug you need at 2am, you already own.

The naming step matters too. Feelings that get named get smaller — not gone, just smaller. Hand on heart is you telling your own nervous system: someone is here. She is.

The world gets your composure. Your chest gets your hand. That's a fair trade.

— ZANE

The Ugly Cry Rule

THE MOMENT IT SAVES: My mum was married for a long time. Longer than I've been alive, actually. When it ended, she did what strong women do — she held it together. She signed things. She made phone calls. She was gracious at the family gathering. Then one Tuesday night I found her sitting on the kitchen floor, back against the cupboard under the sink, crying so hard she couldn't speak. She tried to apologize. She tried to stand up. I sat on the floor next to her and said the only true thing I knew: "Don't stop." So she didn't. It was ugly. Loud, messy, years deep. And when it finally ran out, she did something I hadn't seen her do in months. She exhaled. All the way. Her shoulders came down like someone had cut a wire.

That's the whole rule.

THE HACK:

1. When the cry comes, let it come. Not a tidy tear. The real one.
2. Alone, give it full volume — into a pillow, on the floor, in the shower if the kids are home. A gentle container helps if "forever" feels scary: one playlist, one shower, one sad film.
3. When it stops — and it always stops — drink a glass of water, wash your face, and do one small kind thing for yourself. Tea. A blanket. Bed.

Total time: one container, under 10 minutes — one playlist, one shower, one film scene. You'll spend more energy fighting it than feeling it.

WHY IT WORKS: Crying is the body's discharge valve. Emotional tears literally carry stress hormones out of the body, and a full cry shifts your system from alarm toward recovery. Swallowing it costs you — suppression is a full-time job, and it keeps the stress state switched on. Letting the wave peak is what lets it pass. A woman in a breakup forum, no punctuation, no polish, said it better than any textbook: "ugly crying is by far the most helpful thing i experienced during my break up."

The cry isn't the breakdown. The cry is the exhale your body's been queuing for weeks.

— ZANE

The Car Scream

THE MOMENT IT SAVES: A client of mine — I'll call her Dana — found out about her husband's affair on an ordinary Thursday, and spent three months being reasonable. Reasonable with the lawyer. Reasonable with the kids. Reasonable in front of the woman he'd chosen, at a school event, where Dana actually smiled. Then one afternoon she pulled into the grocery store car park, turned off the engine, and heard a sound come out of her that she didn't know was in her. She screamed until the windows fogged. Then she screamed again. She told me later, "I thought something was wrong with me. Turns out something had been wrong with me for three months, and it finally got loud."

THE HACK:

1. Get in your car alone. Park somewhere quiet — a far corner of a car park, a lay-by, your own driveway at night. Windows up.
2. Set a timer for 2 to 5 minutes.
3. Scream. At him, at the situation, at the unfairness of all of it. Into a folded jacket if you want it muffled. Loud, from the gut, as many times as it takes.
4. When the screaming's done, stay in the seat and say the speech out loud — the one you'd never actually deliver. The whole uncensored version.
5. Sit for thirty seconds. Then drive home.

Total time: under 10 minutes, parked.

WHY IT WORKS: Betrayal leaves your body braced for a fight it was never allowed to have. All that adrenaline has to go somewhere, and screaming is a physical discharge — it burns off the fight energy the same way crying burns off the grief. The car is the perfect container: private, yours, and no one gets hurt. The imaginary speech matters because betrayal steals your voice; this gives it back without paying for the lawyer's letter. One divorced woman put it simply: "Screaming in my car. And then later repeatedly telling him to fuck off in my imagination. It actually has really helped me."

HONEST SCIENCE FLAG: I'll be straight with you — there are no clinical trials on screaming in parked cars. The evidence is the women who swear by it, plus solid logic about how bodies release stress. That's enough for a free hack with no side effects except a sore throat.

The scream was never crazy. What was crazy was being asked to hold it.

Once the body stops screaming, we can teach the mind some new tricks.

— ZANE

STEADY THE MIND

Your body knows how to come down now. The water, the hand on your heart, the cry you finally let out — those got you through the wave. But the wave always brings a voice with it, and the voice talks all night. This is the part where we teach the voice some manners.

— ZANE

The Cartoon Voice

THE MOMENT IT SAVES:

It's 2am and you're winning the argument. The one from March. You've got the perfect line now — the one that would have landed, the one that would have made him finally hear you — and you're delivering it to the ceiling for the fortieth time. You know every word by heart. That's the problem.

THE HACK:

1. Catch the looping sentence. Don't fight it. Just name the exact words it's running on repeat: "He never loved me." "I should have said something."
2. Say the sentence out loud — or in your head if you're not alone — in a cartoon voice. Mickey Mouse. Daffy Duck. The squeakiest one you've got. Say it twice.
3. Too dark to say out loud? Sing it instead, to the tune of "Happy Birthday." Yes, really. "He never posted pictures of uuuus." Full melody.
4. Then close it out with the release line: "I see you, thoughts. Bye bye."

Total time: 30 to 60 seconds per loop.

WHY IT WORKS:

This trick comes from a therapy approach where it's called cognitive defusion. The thought hurts because you're fused with it — you're inside the sentence, believing it. A cartoon voice breaks the weld. The words don't change; your seat does. You move from inside the thought to the audience, watching it, and from the audience it's exactly what it always was: noise your brain makes at 2am, not a verdict.

And notice what this isn't. You're not arguing with the thought, and you're not shoving it down — arguing keeps it alive and suppression brings it back louder. You're just changing the channel it broadcasts on.

A woman in a no-contact forum posted this exact technique — cartoon voice, "Happy Birthday," "I see you thoughts bye bye" — and one reply said it for all of them: "Today has been an especially bad day where I'm ruminating and so close to texting him and this helped me so much."

It feels silly. That's the mechanism. Silly is the distance.

— ZANE

The Third-Person Pep Talk

THE MOMENT IT SAVES:

It hits at the kitchen sink on a Tuesday, both hands in the dishwasher, and suddenly you can't breathe over a plate. You need someone calm to talk you down — and there is no one. Except there is.

THE HACK:

1. When the wave hits, say your own name. First name, the one the people who love you use.
2. Ask her — yourself — two questions, silently or out loud: "Why is [your name] hurting right now?" and "What does [your name] need tonight?"
3. Answer in the second or third person, like you would for your best friend: "Karen's hurting because she saw the photo. Karen needs to eat something and go to bed, not to figure out her whole life at 11pm."
4. Keep it to two minutes. One small instruction is enough. Then do the one small thing.

Total time: about two minutes.

WHY IT WORKS:

I'm going to be plain, because this is the chapter with the strongest science in the book and I don't want to dress it up. In 2017, two university labs ran two experiments — one measuring brain waves, one scanning brains — on how people talk to themselves during painful memories. When people silently coached themselves using their own name instead of "I," their emotional reactivity dropped measurably. And here's the part that matters at 2am: it cost them nothing. No extra mental effort. The scans showed regulation arriving for free. A follow-up study found the effect held even for very intense memories — roughly a tenth less sting, every time, no matter how raw.

The mechanism is almost embarrassingly human. You are brilliant at comforting other people. You've talked friends off ledges for decades. Your own name is the switch that moves you from the woman drowning to the friend on the shore.

One honest note: these were lab studies on painful memories generally, not a trial of heartbroken women specifically. But the effect was so clean and so cheap that it earns its place on its own merit.

You've spent years answering to everyone else's name for you. Tonight, your name answers to you.

— ZANE

The "The" Loop

THE MOMENT IT SAVES:

It's 3am. The house is so quiet you can hear the fridge. You're exhausted — bone-level, please-God exhausted — and your brain has decided this is the perfect moment to re-audit the last six years. Sleep is right there. You can see it. Every time you reach for it, the loop starts the next episode.

THE HACK:

1. Lie still. Let the spiral start — you're not going to wrestle it.
2. Silently, in your head, start repeating one word: "The." Just that. The. The. The. Steady, like a slow metronome.
3. Don't finish the sentence. There is no sentence. When the loop tries to grab the mic — "The — he never—" — gently hand the mic back to "The."
4. Keep going. Most people are asleep before it gets boring. That's the point: it is boring.

Total time: one to five minutes at bedtime.

WHY IT WORKS:

Your inner narrator runs on a single channel — the part of the mind that holds language in a loop, called the verbal buffer — and it can only carry one stream at a time. Rumination works by hogging that stream. "The" fills it with something meaningless and emotionally empty, impossible to build a spiral out of. Your brain keeps waiting for the paragraph that never comes, and waiting is close kin to sleeping.

HONEST SCIENCE FLAG:

I'm not going to oversell this one. Nobody has run a clinical trial on the word "The." It sits in the same family as a researched technique for crowding out mental chatter, but the evidence here is folk wisdom — field-tested by women in the infidelity forums at the worst hours of their lives. One poster explained it better than any paper could: "'The' is a sentence starter and it prepares your mind for a paragraph, do this often enough and you'll fall asleep. I know it helped me get through a few dark moments." That's the whole evidence base: dark moments, survived. Some nights, that's enough.

The strangest tools are the ones that still work when you're too tired to try.

— ZANE

The Pedestal Smash

THE MOMENT IT SAVES:

A client of mine — I'll call her Denise — spent nineteen years married to a man she described, without irony, as "the best thing that ever happened to me." This was three months after he left. By text. I asked her what he did when she cried. She went quiet for a long time. Then she opened her Notes app and started typing, and she didn't stop for twenty minutes. "I think I built him," she told me later. "I built him, and then I worshipped what I built."

THE HACK:

1. Open your Notes app or a notebook. This list is for your eyes only — never send it, never show him.
2. Write down everything. Every time he made you feel small. Every birthday he phoned in, every eye-roll, every promise that evaporated, every night you ate dinner alone while he was "busy." The gross stuff, the petty stuff, the stuff you're embarrassed to admit you tolerated. Nineteen years' worth if that's what there is.
3. Keep the list one thumb-tap away.
4. Every time you start missing him — the exact moment the ache says he was wonderful — read the list. Top to bottom. Add to it whenever a new memory surfaces.

Total time: ten minutes to start, sixty seconds per re-read.

WHY IT WORKS:

A heartbroken brain runs an edited highlight reel. It plays the holiday and cuts the silence in the car on the way home. That's not weakness; it's how memory works under longing — and it keeps the attachment chemically alive. In 2018, researchers hooked recent dumpees up to brain-wave monitors and tested strategies for turning love down. The winner was deliberately dwelling on the ex's negative qualities — it measurably decreased love feelings. Your list isn't bitterness. It's the deleted scenes. Watching them is what restores the film to its true length.

Denise keeps hers to this day. She calls it her anchor — the same word a woman on a divorce forum used: "I call list 2 my 'anchor' so I don't drift off into the waters of regret. It grounds me in the reality of why it didn't work."

*Here's the whole hack in one line, so screenshot it: **Write it when you're strong. Read it when you're weak.***

— ZANE

BREAK THE LOOP

Now the hard truth, said gently. Three separate kinds of evidence point at the same uncomfortable picture. Brain scans of rejected lovers show the same circuitry firing that fires in cocaine craving. Therapists and the women in the forums independently landed on the same word: addiction. And when researchers followed people checking an ex's social media, they found every check predicted feeling worse — not just that night, but the next day too. A next-day emotional hangover, one researcher called it.

So we're done asking you to resist him with willpower. Willpower is a 3am resource and the urges are 3am creatures. Instead, we change the room, the phone, and the path of least resistance. Not your character. Your environment.

The Full Purge

THE MOMENT IT SAVES:

You told yourself you were just checking. Just one look at his profile, just to see if he's hurting too. Forty minutes later you're six photos deep into a woman you've never met, studying her smile like it's evidence in your own trial, and your chest feels like someone is standing on it. He posted her. He never posted you. Nothing about this is information. It's the same wound, reopened on schedule.

THE HACK:

Do this once, in a single ten-minute sitting, in daylight. Not at midnight.

1. **Block everywhere.** Every app, every platform, plus the phone number. Include his close friends and anyone whose posts feature him. *(4 min)*
2. **Delete the thread.** The whole text history. Do not scroll it "one last time" first — that's the trap. Screenshot anything legally or practically necessary into a hidden folder first, then let it go. *(2 min)*
3. **Vault the photos.** Move them to the hidden album, then turn the hidden album off in settings, or into a cloud folder. Not deleted — vaulted. You're packing away the winter clothes, not burning them. Gentler, and it works. *(2 min)*
4. **Box the mementos.** One box, a lid, the top of a wardrobe. *(1 min)*
5. **TEXT ONE FRIEND:** "I've blocked him. Please don't give me updates." *(30 seconds)*

Total time: one ten-minute session. Maintenance after that is zero — that's the design.

Not ready to block? Use the ladder: mute first, then unfollow, then block. Check yourself weekly — if you're still typing his name into the search bar, muting left the door cracked, and you climb.

Co-parenting? You can't vanish, so shrink him instead: mute everywhere except one communication app used for the kids only. Logistics live there. Nothing else does.

WHY IT WORKS:

Every profile check is a hit. It re-primers the craving circuitry and resets the clock — the research on ex-surveillance is blunt: checking predicts more distress, more longing, and that next-day hangover. And here's the piece that proves this is about environment, not character: in one six-week study, adding a few seconds of friction before an app opened — one pause, one "are you sure?" — cut how often people opened it by more than half. Nobody became a stronger person. The path just got longer. The Full Purge makes the path a hundred miles long, once, so you never have to be strong about it again.

— ZANE

One woman who finally did it wrote that deleting the photos "was one of the hardest things I've ever done" — and that a hundred strangers called her brave for it. Nobody calls keeping them brave.

— ZANE

The 48-Hour Letter

THE MOMENT IT SAVES:

It's 11:47pm. You've composed the text four times in your head and now your thumbs are doing it for real. This one is different. Dignified but honest, wounded but witty — if he reads it at exactly the right moment he will finally understand. Every version of that text has been written at 11:47pm by every woman who has ever lived. None of them ever landed the way the night promised.

THE HACK:

1. Open a locked note on your phone. Title it whatever keeps your hands honest — "UNSENT" works.
2. Type the whole message there. Uncensored. The rage, the grief, the perfect closing line, all of it. Word-vomit speed. Don't edit.
3. Lock it. Put a 48-hour timer on your decision, not your feelings: if it still feels necessary in two days, you may re-read it and decide again.
4. In two days, re-read it. Then notice what happened to the urgency.

Total time: five to ten minutes per urge.

A woman on a divorce forum told the truth about how this goes: "No lie, every single email or letter that I began was supposed to end up being sent. But by the time I was able to either just stop myself from writing or just from sheer emotional exhaustion I would never end up pressing send." Every single one. Sent by nobody.

WHY IT WORKS:

The urge to reach out is a spike, not a decision. It feels permanent because you're standing inside it, but urges decay — fast — and forty-eight hours outlasts almost every one of them. Writing the message lets the pressure out through your thumbs instead of through your dignity: the feeling moves from your chest into language, and language can be locked in a note. He never gets the message. You get the relief. That's the entire trade, and you win both sides of it.

HONEST SCIENCE FLAG:

One boundary, and it matters. This letter is a pressure valve, not grief work. There's a real finding here: in one trial of recently separated people, those assigned deep, unstructured emotional writing too early actually fared worse months later. So hear the rule of this book clearly — this note discharges the urge and nothing more. The deep writing, the kind that processes the loss itself, comes later, when you're steadier. The letter's job tonight is smaller and nobler: keep the text from sending.

— ZANE

Write him everything. Send him nothing. Keep your side of the street clean and your no-contact clock running.

— ZANE

Text Her Instead

THE MOMENT IT SAVES:

The urge doesn't announce itself as an urge. It announces itself as a reason. He'd want to know about the promotion. This meme is so him. It's his mother's birthday, it would be cruel not to. Your thumb is already hovering. What's actually happening, under all the reasons, is that you're lonely and he used to be the place loneliness went. That place is closed. The loneliness is real. It just needs a new address.

THE HACK:

1. Decide in daylight, once: the rule is five. Before any text to him, you must send five texts to five real people who love you.
2. Keep them tiny. A meme to your sister. A photo of the dog to your college friend. "Thinking of you, that's all" to your cousin. Two minutes each, tops.
3. Count them. One. Two. Three. Watch what the urge does somewhere around number four.
4. If the urge is somehow still standing after five, you don't text him — you call the one friend who made the pact with you, and you say "talk me down." That's her whole job.

Total time: about five minutes per urge.

WHY IT WORKS:

The reaching-out impulse is withdrawal wearing a disguise. It isn't asking for him — it's asking for connection, for someone on the other end. Five small texts deliver the actual need from five safe sources, and a need that's been met stops shouting. Meanwhile the old habit — every lonely feeling routes to him — gets starved a rep at a time. A woman who did exactly this wrote: "When I wanted to text him, I texted my BFF instead. Slowly, my bruised and broken heart is healing and coming back together."

One guardrail, and hold it firm: your people redirect, they don't rehash. When two people circle the same hurt over and over, it deepens the bond and the low mood at the same time — researchers have watched it happen. So give your five a job description: distract me, remind me, make me laugh. Not "let's analyze him again at midnight." Buddies are for rescue, not for reopening the case file.

He stopped being your emergency contact. These five women are the emergency contacts now.

— ZANE

The Feel-Good Menu

THE MOMENT IT SAVES:

It's 11pm. The house went quiet hours ago and you've done that thing where you opened the app to check one notification and resurfaced ninety minutes later, hollow. Your thumb knows the route to his page the way your car knows the route to work. You're not even enjoying it. You're just ordering from the only menu that's open at this hour — and the kitchen serves nothing but doom.

THE HACK:

Build your own menu once, on a good day, in ten minutes. Then it's there on the bad nights.

1. **Write five appetizers** — two-minute things that reliably lift you even a notch. Sun on your face with eyes closed. One song danced badly in the kitchen. A text with a meme to someone funny. Stepping outside and finding the moon. The good hand cream.
2. **Write three entrées** — twenty-to-thirty-minute things for a whole evening that needs saving. A bath with the door locked. Cooking one real meal like you matter. An episode of the show he hated.
3. **Write one special** — the occasional big treat. Dinner out with the loud friend. The movie at the cinema, alone, with the good popcorn.
4. **Put the menu where the urge lives.** Phone lock screen, fridge, nightstand.
5. When the stalk-or-scroll urge hits, don't resist it — **order an appetizer**. The rule is only that you order from your menu before you order from his.

Total time: ten minutes to build, two minutes per use.

WHY IT WORKS:

This trick went viral online — one reader called it "a feel-good cheat sheet" — but the engine under it is decades old and clinical: it's a direct descendant of a core depression therapy technique called pleasant-activity scheduling. Two things make it work at 11pm. First, your reward system is running on fumes after a breakup, and small pleasant actions drip it back to life one dose at a time. Second — and this is the quiet genius of the menu — the deciding is already done. Willpower fails at night because deciding is work. You're not deciding anything. You're ordering off a menu, like a woman who knows what she likes.

Scrolling is also on the menu, by the way — it's just listed under desserts. Small portions. Not dinner.

You've spent years reading everyone else's tastes. This menu is the first document of yours.

The loop is broken. Now we rebuild the woman.

— ZANE

REBUILD HER

Here's what I've learned from hundreds of women who made it through: nobody thinks their way back to a self. The identity doesn't return in a journal insight or a therapy breakthrough. It comes back through the hands. Ten-minute reps, done badly, done daily — and the self comes back as evidence. These last three hacks are where the rebuild becomes visible.

— ZANE

The Before-Him Revival

THE MOMENT IT SAVES: Years ago, after my own relationship ended, a friend asked me what music I liked. I opened my mouth and nothing came out. I knew what *we* listened to. I knew what she loved. Somewhere along the way my own taste had gone quiet — not erased, just shelved. My way back was embarrassingly small: ten minutes a day of something I'd abandoned. One old album. One sketchbook. Ten minutes, no audience, no point except that it was mine. It worked faster than anything else I tried.

THE HACK:

1. One time, write a list of 10 things you loved before him — the music, the hobby, the food, the place, the weird little show. Things that got crowded out. If you can't remember, ask a friend who knew you then. She'll remember faster than you will.
2. Each day, pick one. Do it for exactly 10 minutes. Play the album. Sketch badly. Make the recipe. Dance to one song in the kitchen like nobody's grading you — because nobody is.
3. Tick it off. When the list runs dry, write a new one. The list refilling is the point: it's your self, returning item by item.

Total time: 10 minutes a day. Do it in the parked car if that's the only ten minutes you own.

WHY IT WORKS: A breakup doesn't just remove a person — it shrinks your sense of who you are. Researchers call it a drop in self-concept clarity, and it's the part that hurts most at 2am. In a 2015 study, recently separated people who spent two weeks doing short rediscovery-of-self activities showed measurably rebuilt self-concept clarity and less loneliness — not because they were distracted, but because they were re-collecting themselves. You're not finding a new you. You're clocking back in to the old one.

A client of mine went back to a ceramics class her ex-husband would have found impractical. "I cried in the car afterward," she told me. "Not because it was bad. Because it was mine."

Ten minutes of yours, daily. That's the whole price of getting yourself back.

— ZANE

Little Tombstones

Read this first. This is the only hack in the book with a gate on it. Don't do it in week one. One trial that followed divorcing couples for nine months found that raw, deep-feelings writing done too early can actually slow recovery — especially in women who already ruminate heavily. Feelings need a container before they need a shovel. So install the regulation tools first — the Emergency Brake, the 20-Second Hold, the Ugly Cry Rule, everything from hacks 1 through 8. When those are yours, come back here.

THE MOMENT IT SAVES: My mum stayed in a long marriage, and when it ended she didn't just lose a husband. She lost the house she thought she'd grow old in. The retirement plans. The version of seventy she'd been promised for thirty years. Nobody sends flowers for those. She grieved a man everyone could see, and a future nobody could. What finally moved her was saying goodbye to each one — explicitly, out loud, one at a time.

THE HACK:

1. Take one page. Answer three prompts, one line each: *What do I resent? What do I miss? What dreams must I bury?* Don't write essays. One line holds more than a paragraph here.
2. For every dead dream — the house, the trip, the anniversary that won't happen — write a single line, and say goodbye to it out loud. Yes, out loud. It feels strange once. Then it doesn't.
3. Keep the page somewhere private. When a new undeclared loss surfaces — and it will, usually on an ordinary Tuesday — give it a line and a goodbye too.

Total time: 5–10 minutes, and not one minute more. This is a burial, not a residence.

WHY IT WORKS: A clinical psychologist whose talk on this has been watched millions of times puts it plainly: "You have to say goodbye to these things and put up little tombstones for them. One of the reasons people have trouble finishing the grief process is because there are so many undeclared losses — the hopes, the dreams you had together." Grief stalls when losses stay unnamed. Naming a dream and burying it deliberately is what lets the feeling complete its course instead of circling forever.

You can't grieve what you won't admit you lost. Say its name, and let it rest.

— ZANE

The Letter from Her

THE MOMENT IT SAVES: The night after the tombstones. When the grieving is done and the quiet feels less like a wound and more like a room — an empty room you now have to decide how to furnish. Every hack before this one looked at what you lost or what he did. This is the last hack in the book, and it's the only one that looks forward instead of back. It's for the moment you catch yourself asking, *okay — so who am I now?* and, for once, wanting an answer instead of fearing the question.

THE HACK:

1. Take a blank page. Date it one year from today. That date matters — this isn't a wish, it's a dispatch.
2. Write 5–8 lines in the present tense, from the woman who made it. Not the fantasy version — the real one. Where she wakes up. What her mornings feel like. What she does on a Tuesday. Who sits at her table. What she's proud of surviving.
3. End with one line of advice from her to you, the woman reading this tonight. Just one. She's twelve months ahead of you on the same road. She knows what you need to hear.

Total time: 10 minutes. Once — though many women rewrite hers every few months, and each draft gets closer.

WHY IT WORKS: In a 2001 study, people who wrote about their best possible future selves didn't just feel more optimistic — their health measurably improved, without the emotional hangover that heavy grief-writing can cause. Replications since have found the effect holds. Which means this exercise was practically built for you. A vividly imagined future self does something no affirmation can: it gives the present a direction. She becomes evidence you're walking toward.

One woman wrote hers like this: "I hope you open your eyes in a space that feels like yours — not borrowed, not tolerated, not survived in. Chosen."

That's the whole book, really. He may be the reason it starts. She's the reason it ends.

— ZANE

The Honest Science Corner

I promised you honest science, so here it is — all fifteen hacks, sorted by how much proof is actually behind them.

Proven. The Emergency Brake (the dive reflex is well-documented physiology). The 20-Second Hold (a randomized trial found self-touch lowered stress hormones). The Third-Person Pep Talk (brain-imaging studies show saying your own name dials down reactivity). The Pedestal Smash (deliberately un-idealizing an ex measurably reduced love feelings in a lab study). The Full Purge (study after study links checking an ex's social media to worse recovery — one found a next-day emotional hangover). The Before-Him Revival (a randomized rediscovery-of-self trial). The Letter from Her (best-possible-self writing, studied and replicated since 2001).

Promising. The Ugly Cry Rule (crying does shift the body out of fight-or-flight — the mechanism is real, the trials are thin). The Cartoon Voice (cognitive defusion is a real therapy technique; the studies are small). The "The" Loop (solid mechanism, folk-wisdom evidence, as its own chapter admits). The 48-Hour Letter and Little Tombstones (both rest on real writing research — and both carry the early-deep-writing caution: deep emotional writing done too soon can backfire, which is why the letter stays an urge valve and the tombstones stay behind their gate). Text Her Instead (the withdrawal logic is sound; the five-text version is community-built). The Feel-Good Menu (a direct descendant of a clinical depression technique in a friendlier outfit). Solid logic, thinner trials. I use every one of these. I'm just not going to pretend they've been through the same testing as the first group.

Anecdote-only — use with care. The Car Scream. As its own chapter admits, there are no clinical trials on screaming in parked cars. The evidence is the women who swear by it, plus solid logic about how bodies discharge stress. It's free and the worst side effect is a sore throat, so it stays in the book — but you deserve to know which shelf it sits on.

Went viral — not in this book, use with care. Somatic shaking and tremoring: millions of women swear by it, and there is not one controlled trial behind it — it's also easy to overdo. "Let them": genuinely wise, nearly two decades of therapy in two words, and completely unstudied. Weighted blankets: the evidence is real but narrower than the hype — strongest for sleep, not an anxiety cure. None of these three is one of the fifteen. They're here because you'll see them everywhere, and you deserve the same honesty about them.

Where the science was thin, I've told you. You've been sold magic before. Not here. You deserve tools, not fairy tales.

— ZANE

The Next Step

Here's what just happened, whether it feels like it yet or not.

You did fifteen reps of proof. Proof that you can calm your own body at 2am. Proof that you can interrupt a thought loop, starve a craving, grieve what died, and write to the woman you're becoming. That's not a reading achievement. That's evidence — and evidence is the only thing self-worth has ever been built from. Not affirmations. Not someone choosing you. Receipts.

And notice something: nobody in these pages rescued anybody. The women in this book — the ones who wrote to me, the ones in the studies, maybe you — they did the reps. I only carried the tools to the door.

You're not broken. You never were. You're being rebuilt — and now you've seen the scaffolding with your own eyes.

But I'll tell you the truth I told you at the start: I'm just a guy who listened. These fifteen hacks came from women who did the work — and nearly every one of them said the same thing about what made it stick. *Someone to do it with.*

That's why Myself Again exists.

It's the Scarred Truth cohort — **one month, August 15 to September 15, 2026**, of doing this exact work together. Not another course you'll abandon by week two. A room of women who get it — women who know the supermarket aisle, the quiet house at 2am, the good plate on a Tuesday — walking the same thirty days you are, with me guiding each step. The reps, the containers, the tombstones, the letter. Done together, witnessed, kept.

You will have hard nights inside that month. Everyone does. The difference is that this time, on the hard night, a room full of women will know exactly what your 2am looks like — because it looks like theirs.

Doors are open now, and they close when the cohort fills.

Join us at <https://scarredtruth.com/join-myself-again-cohort>

You don't have to feel ready. Ready was never the requirement. Showing up for ten minutes was — and you've already done that fifteen times.

Come do the sixteenth with us.

— Zane

That's the scarred truth.

— Zane

— Zane